Palestine, not just the area allocated to the Jewish state by the UN.

Fatah A Palestinian guerrilla group founded by Yasser Arafat. Its general strategy was to drag the Arab states into war with Israel so that a Palestinian state might be established.

Fedayeen Men trained to carry out raids (literally, 'those who sacrifice themselves').

'Green line' The border between Israel and the West Bank before the 1967 Six-Day War.

Guerrillas Soldiers who avoid fighting in open battle when possible; they prefer to use tactics like ambushes and hit-and-run raids.

Haganah The Jewish Defence Force, which was set up in the 1920s and was later to form the basis of the Israeli army.

Hamas Founded in Gaza in 1988 by Sheikh Ahmed Yassin, a religious teacher. The movement opposed the Oslo Accords and refused to recognise the state of Israel.

High Commissioner The most senior diplomat, like an ambassador, representing the British government.

Hizbollah A radical Islamic group based in southern Lebanon.

Imperialism Rule by one nation or people over another.

Insurgency An uprising to try and overthrow a government.

'International communism' A term used by the US government to describe the threat posed by the communist Soviet Union and its allies during the Cold War.

Intifada The Palestinian uprising that erupted in Gaza and the West Bank in 1987.

Irgun A small secret Zionist organisation which fought for a Jewish state in all of Palestine.

Islamic fundamentalism The belief that the state should be based wholly on Islamic law, as in Muhammad's day.

Islamists Those who believe in political Islam.

Israeli Defence Force (IDF) The Israeli armed forces, most of whose members had been in the Haganah.

Israelites The name by which Jews were known in ancient times, hence the 'Land of Israel' was their Promised Land.

Jewish Agency The governing body of the Zionist movement in Palestine during the British mandate.

Jihad An Arabic word meaning 'struggle', both internal and personal (against sin) and external (against threats to Muslim lands).

Kibbutzim Settlements in Israel where people live and work together.

Koran The holy book of the Muslims which, they believe, contains the word of God as conveyed to the Prophet Muhammad in the seventh century AD.

Kurds The Kurds are Muslims but not Arab. They form about 20 per cent of the Iraqi population and are concentrated in the north of the country.

Lobbied To lobby is to win the support of members of a law-making body (e.g. the US Congress) so as to shape its policy.

Mandate An order or a command, in this case from the League of Nations, giving Britain and France control of Arab lands previously ruled by Turkey. Britain and France were to prepare the Arab lands for eventual self-government.

Martial law Military government, with ordinary law suspended.

Martyr Someone who dies or suffers greatly for a cause, especially for religious beliefs. There is a particularly strong tradition of martyrdom among Shiites.